Game Report: Milwaukee Bucks vs Oklahoma City Thunder NBA Cup Final 12/17/2024

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Game Context

In the NBA Cup Final between the Milwaukee Bucks and the Oklahoma City Thunder, the Bucks prevailed 97 to 81.

Giannis Antetokounmpo and Shai Gilgeous-Alexander led their teams in scoring with **26** and **23**.

The game was competitive in the first half, but the Bucks extended their lead by outscoring the Thunder **26** to **14** in the third quarter.

The Thunder team shot **33.7%** overall, with **15.6%** from three-point range. In the third quarter, they shot **26.3%** field goal percentage and **28.6%** from three-point range. (Had FG% of 48.2 and 3P% of 31.3 previously).

How the Bucks Won Their First NBA Cup: 5 Key Takeaways

Milwaukee Scored From All Over the Floor
The Bucks spread their shot attempts across the half court — inside, mid-range, and beyond the arc — keeping OKC's defense off balance. In contrast, OKC mostly attacked from the middle and became predictable.

Defensive Game Plan Worked on OKC's Star
Shai Gilgeous-Alexander was held to lower shot quality than usual. Milwaukee's defensive pressure limited his ability to take over the game.

Clutch Execution Made the Difference
The Bucks outperformed the Thunder during key stretches — especially late in the 1st half and especially in the 3rd quarter — swinging momentum in their favor.

More Efficient with Similar Shot Quality
Despite both teams generating comparable shot quality, the Bucks were significantly more efficient in converting those chances, reflecting better shot selection and execution.

Room to Grow: High-Quality Shooters Underperformed
Players like **Prince** and **Jackson Jr.** had great opportunities but didn't convert. Focusing on confidence and rhythm could unlock more scoring potential.

Bucks' Shot Efficiency and Zone Control Outpaced Thunder

The Bucks demonstrated superior perimeter efficiency, hitting **41%** of their outside shots vs OKC's **16%** (A1: Shot Chart For the Bucks & Thunder).

Milwaukee demonstrated a stronger performance within the paint, right wing, and corner areas of the court. (A2: Shot Chart For the Bucks & Thunder & (A3:Shot Zone & Shot Type Percentages).

The Bucks were more efficient on layups and post attempts, while OKC struggled with 3-point shooting. (A3: Shot Zone & Shot Type Percentages).

Milwaukee distributed shots more evenly compared to the Thunder, and the Thunder relied on mid-range jumpers (A2: Shot Chart For the Bucks & Thunder).

Efficiency Under Pressure: Milwaukee Delivered, OKC Faltered

While both the Thunder and Bucks had a similar Shot Quality, the Bucks had a much better field goal percentage. (A4: Average Shot Quality Team & Individual)

Several Bucks players posted exceptionally high FG% during the final 4 minutes of the first half and throughout the 3rd quarter (A6: Individual Shot Quality & Field Goal Percentage (Important Time).

The Thunder had several players with a high shot quality percentage, but not all converted their attempts during the game. (A5,A6,A7)

The bucks did a great job containing Shai throughout the game 10th in Shot quality overall and had a **30.8%** FG% (A5:Individual Shot Quality & Field Goal Percentage)

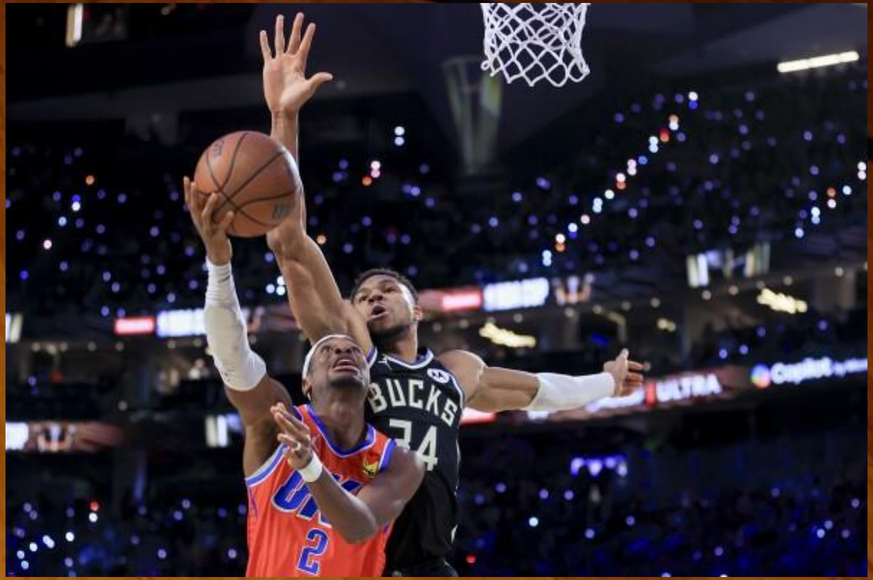
Bucks Capitalized on Limited Open Looks; Thunder Failed to Convert

The Bucks took advantage of lightly contested shots as they shot much higher compared to OKC (**48%** to **17%**). (A10: Contest Level Graph Results & Defender Distance FG%)

Bucks players not only scored more efficiently than the Thunder, but also effectively defended Shai — limiting him to 10th in Points Per Shot. (A9: Points Per Shot Top 10)

The Thunder did not capitalize on field goals when the defender distancer was more than 6 ft whereas the bucks were able to. (A10 & A11)

While the Bucks outperformed the Thunder from three, only two of their attempts were uncontested — indicating a need to improve spacing and generate more open looks. (A8: Shot Contest Model)



What the Data Reveals About the Bucks' Shot Success (A12)

Key Drivers: Shot area, shooter speed, and clock pressure were top predictors — confirming Milwaukee's edge in efficient zones and quick execution.

Game Alignment: Model features reflect game trends: Bucks created quality looks, moved well, and converted under pressure.

Model Limitations: The model struggled to predict which shots would go in — showing that things like confidence, momentum, and timing still play a big role.

Analytical Insights Behind the Bucks' Victory

1. Efficient Shot Conversion
Milwaukee finished above expected shot quality (qSQ), converting both contested and open looks. OKC, despite similar opportunities, underperformed.

2. Missed Open Opportunities by OKC
Thunder shooters converted just **17%** of attempts when the defender was 6+ feet away, compared to a much higher efficiency from the Bucks.

3. Defensive Pressure on Key Players
Milwaukee held Shai Gilgeous-Alexander to **10th** in Points Per Shot despite his usual efficiency, and limited OKC's success on lightly contested shots.

4. More Effective Use of Floor Space
Bucks thrived in the paint and corner/right wing zones. In contrast, OKC struggled in traditionally high-efficiency areas like corner 3s and midrange.

5. Pivotal Stretches in the First Half and Third Quarter Defined the Game
Milwaukee pulled away during the third quarter, shooting **15%** better than OKC in that stretch. It proved to be the decisive turning point.

Next Steps

1. **Start Stronger in Early Quarters**

- Milwaukee's slow first-half start left room for risk. Emphasize pace, spacing, and play execution early to set the tone.

2. Keep Pressure on Opposing Stars

- The Bucks limited Shai's shot quality and scoring. Use a similar defensive strategy to contain the next opponent's primary scorer.

3. Evaluate High-Quality Shooters Who Underperformed

- Jackson Jr. and Prince had great shot quality but low conversion — focus on boosting confidence and consistency.

4. Keep Creating Space — and Contesting It

- MIL shot over 50% when defenders were 6+ feet away, while OKC missed many of those same looks. Maintain offensive spacing and defensive pressure to swing efficiency.

5. **Optimize Shot Selection Based on Contest Level**

Bucks took a balanced mix of uncontested and lightly contested shots across distances. Keep prioritizing cleaner looks and avoiding rushed attempts.

Executive Summary: Bucks vs Thunder (NBA Cup Final)

Milwaukee's 97–81 win over OKC was driven by balanced scoring, high-efficiency shooting, and smart defensive execution

Scoring Versatility: Milwaukee attacked from all zones; OKC focused too narrowly on the midrange.

Efficiency on Equal Quality: Both teams had similar shot quality, but the Bucks finished at a much higher rate.

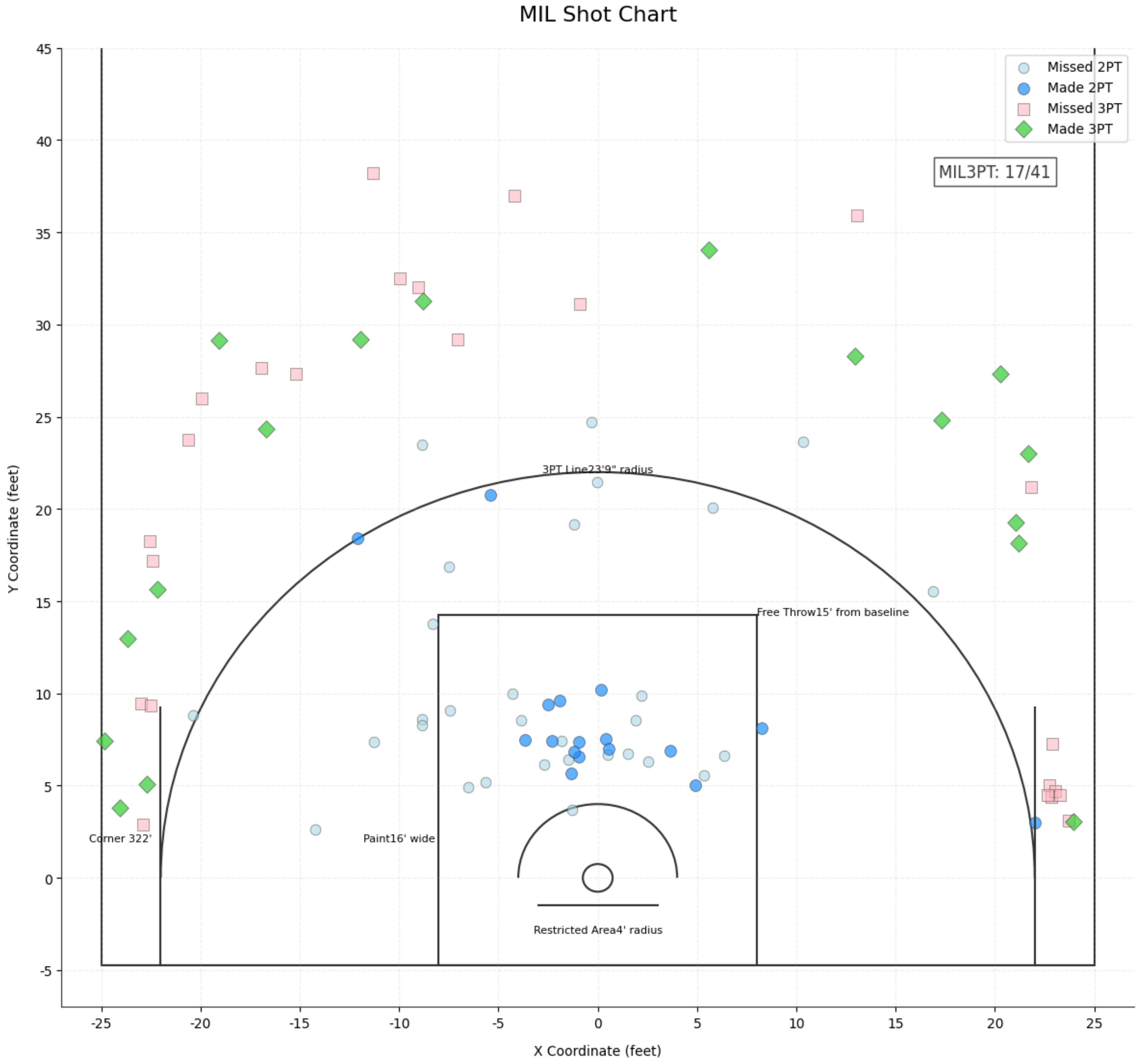
Defensive Pressure on Shai: The Bucks contained OKC's lead scorer by reducing his shot quality through targeted matchups.

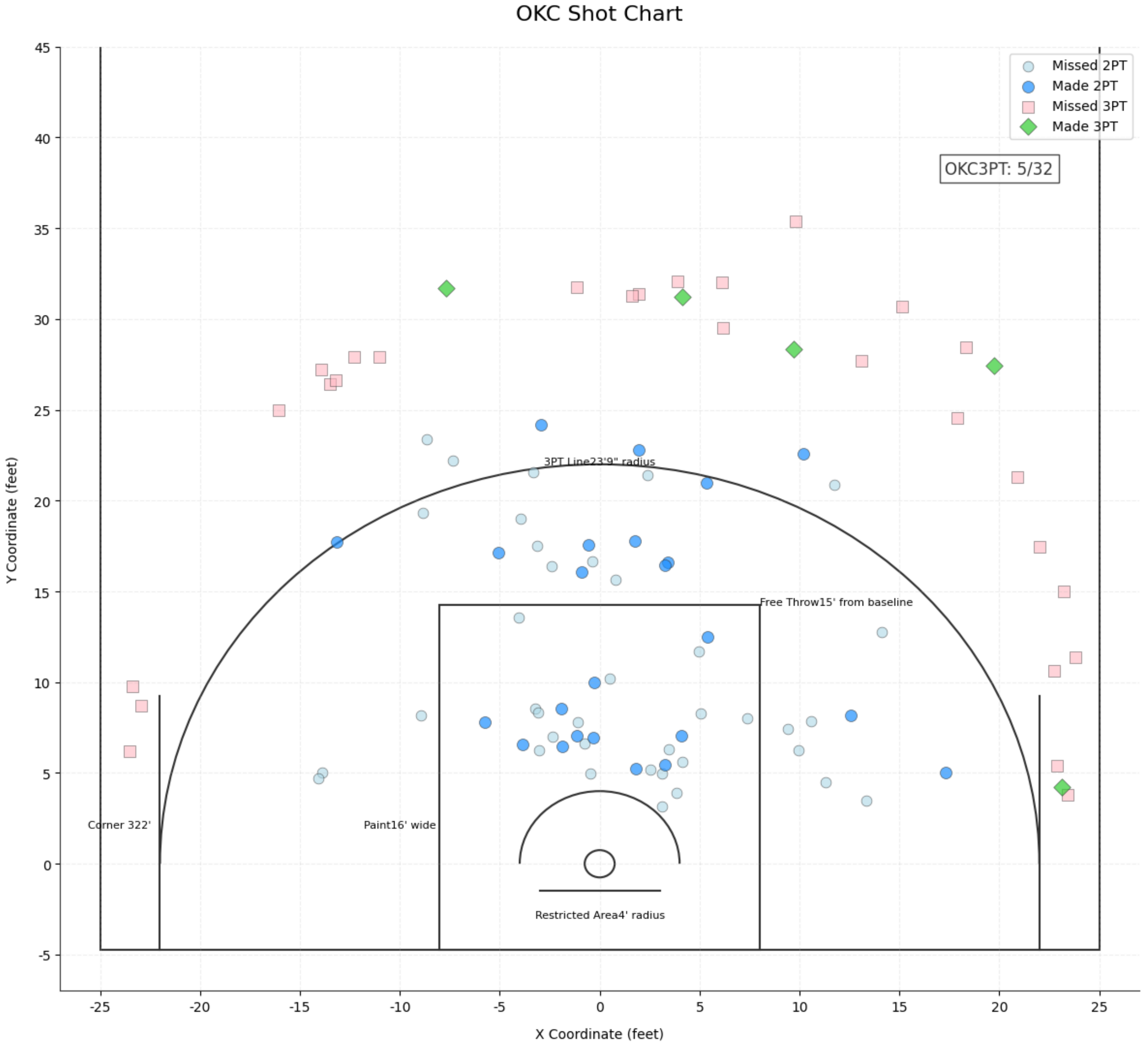
Momentum in Clutch Moments: Milwaukee dominated the 3rd quarter and end of the 1st half to take control.

Missed Opportunities from Role Players: Despite strong shot quality, Prince and Jackson Jr. couldn't convert — a margin for future improvement.

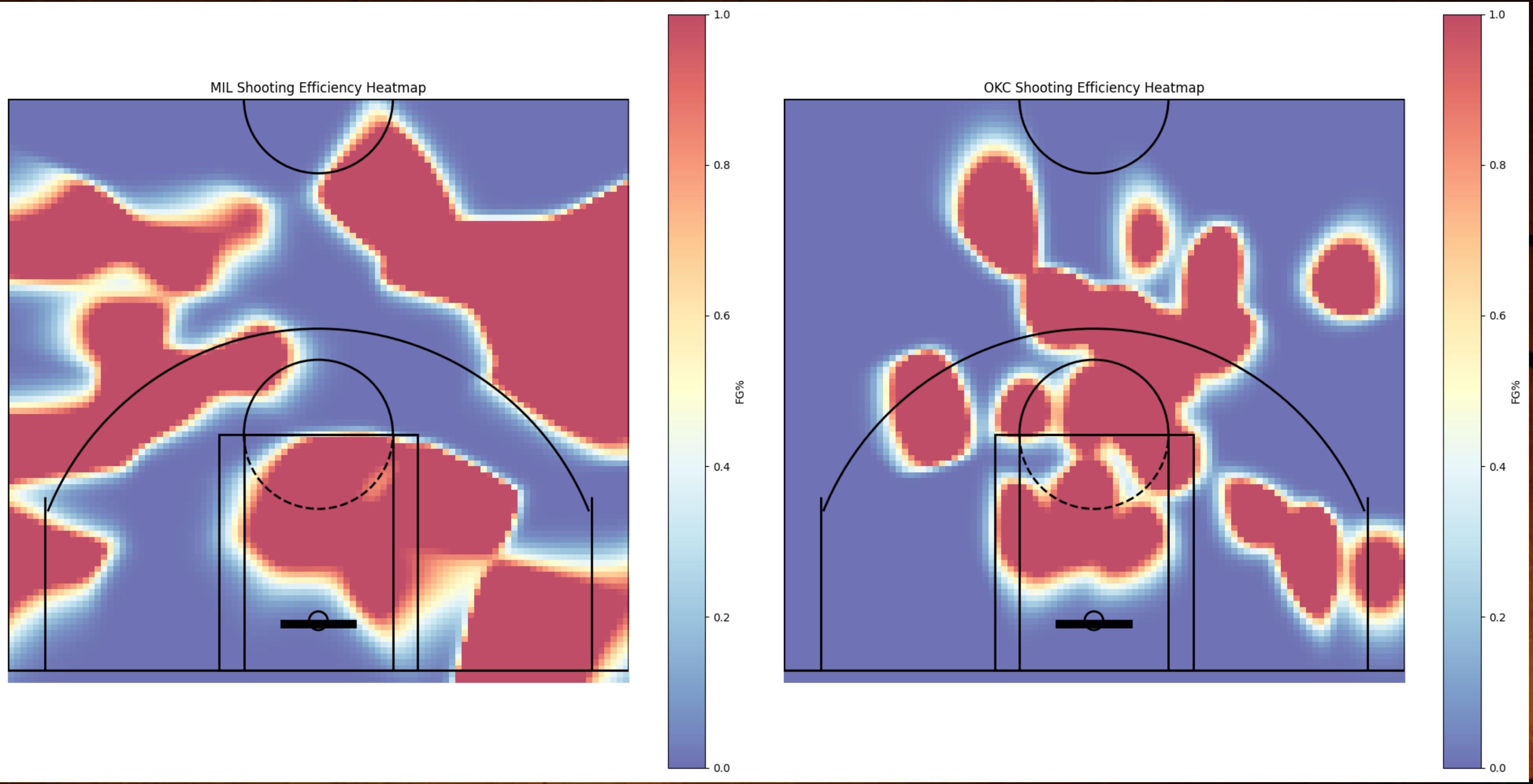

Appendix

A1: Shot Chart For the Bucks & Thunder



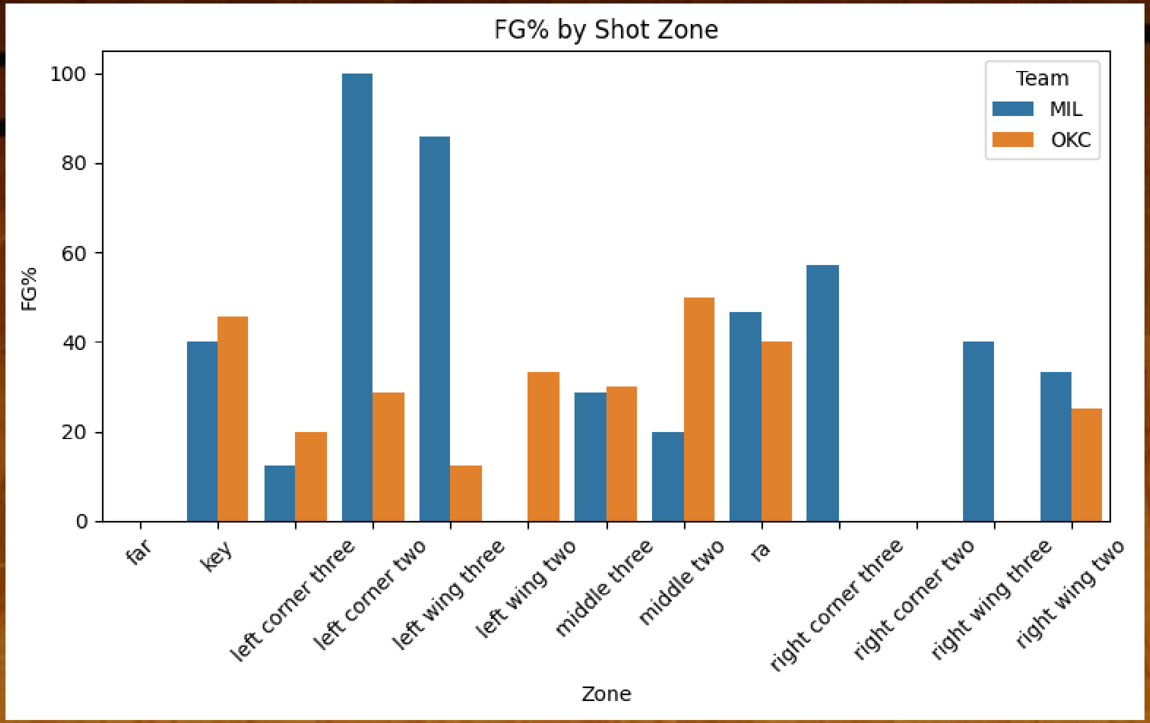


A2: Shooting Efficiency Between MIL VS OKC

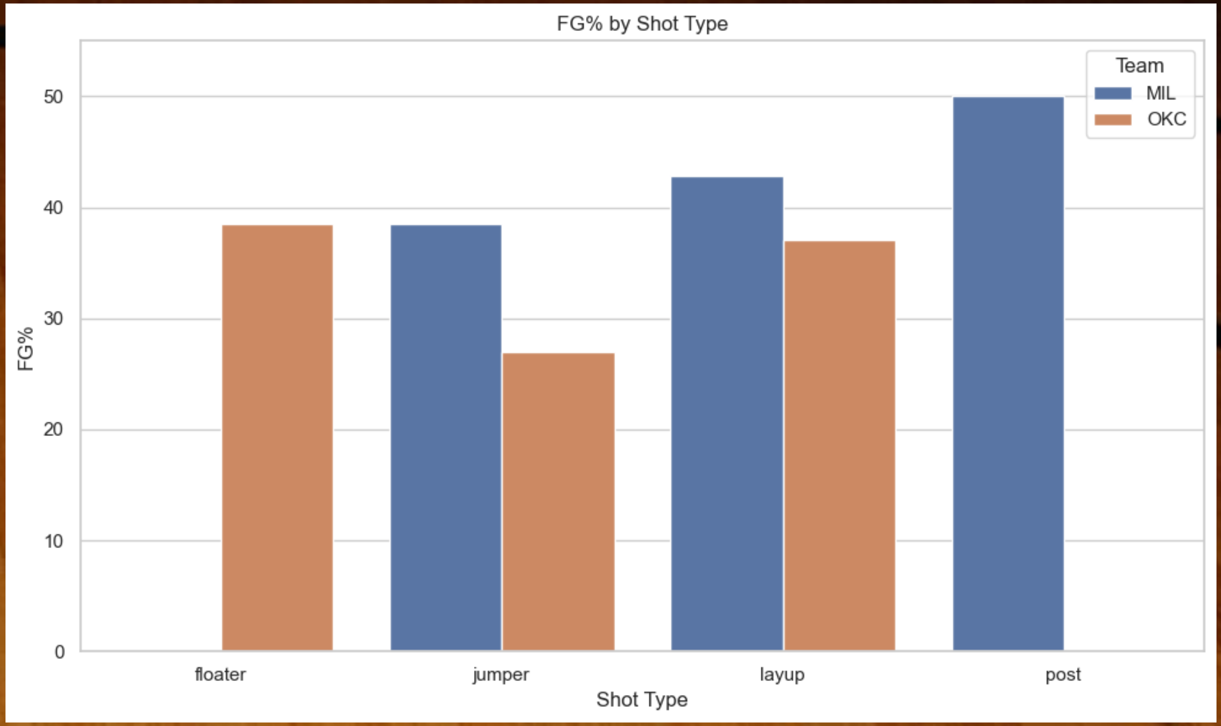


A3: Shot Zone & Shot Type Percentages

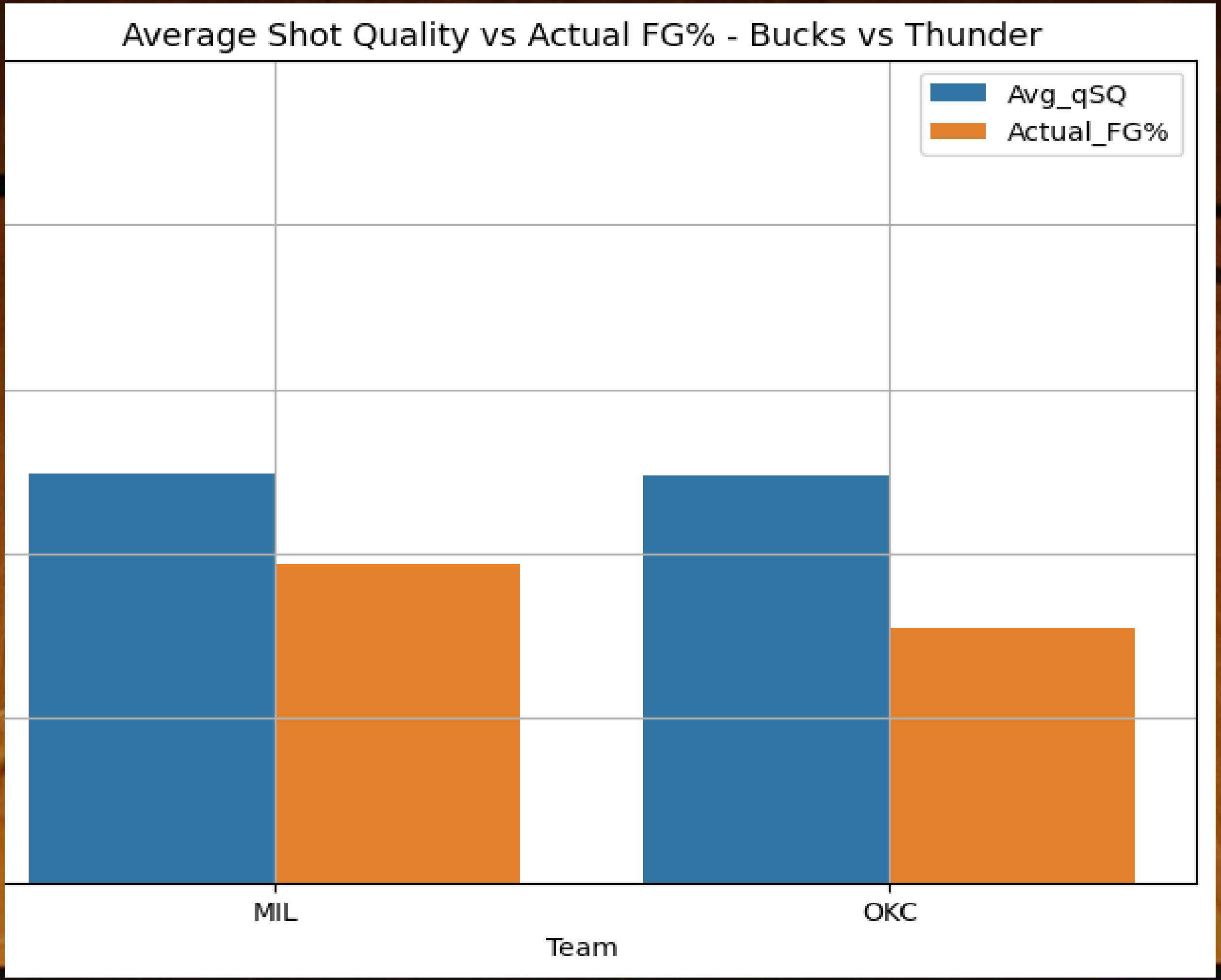
Field Goal % by Shot Zone MIL VS OKC



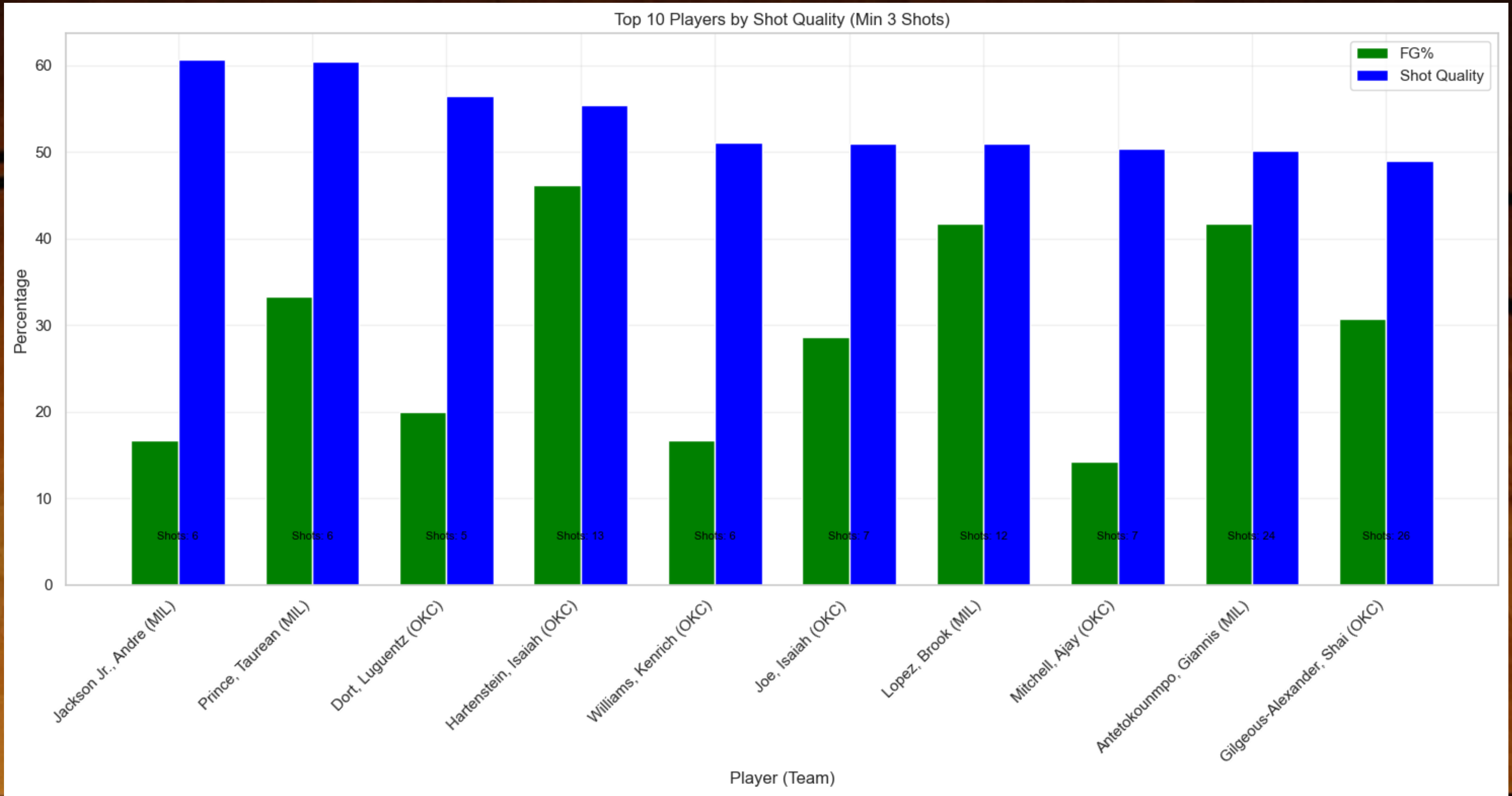
Field Goal % by Shot Type MIL VS OKC



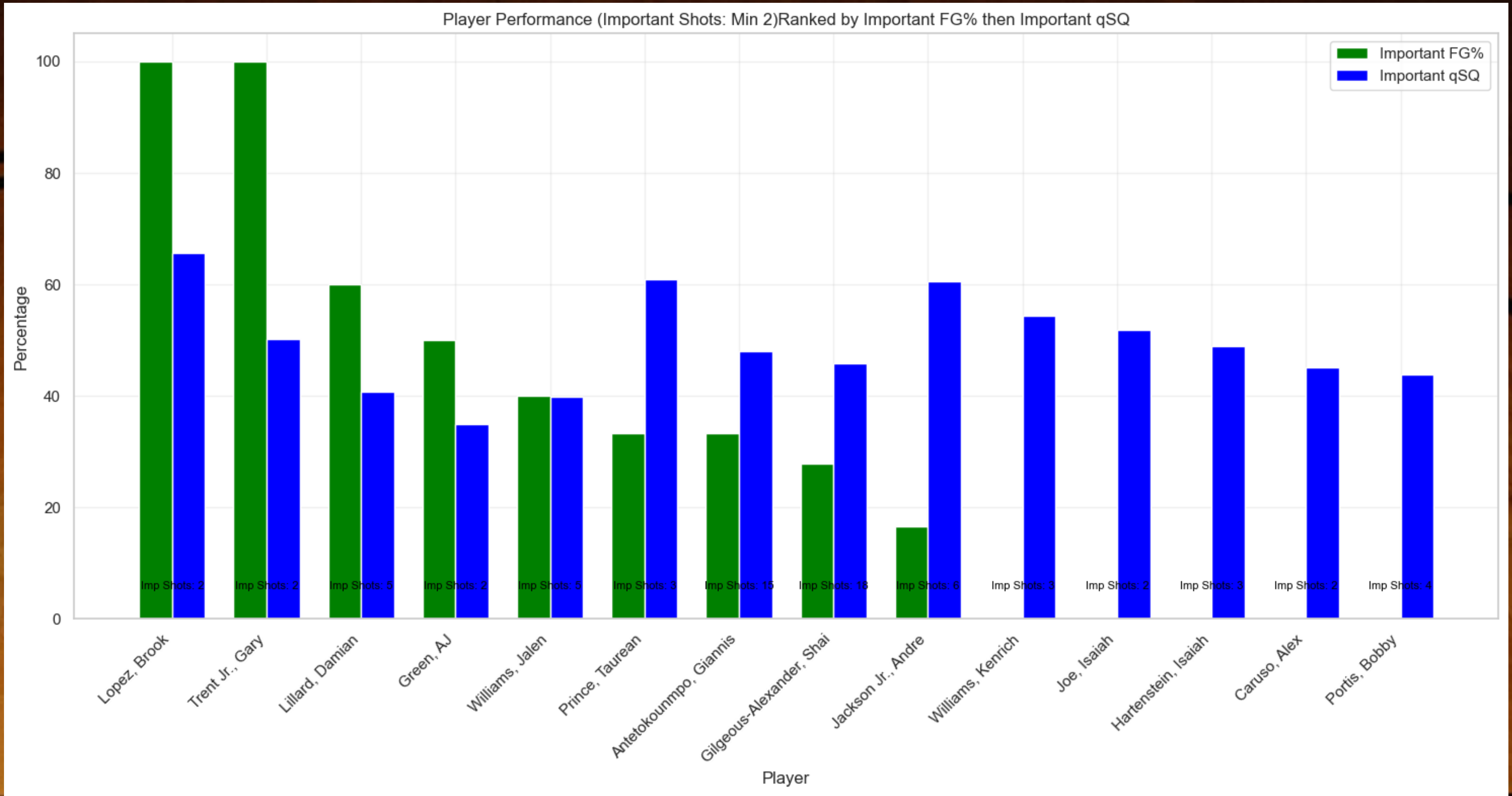
A4: Average Shot Quality Team & Individual

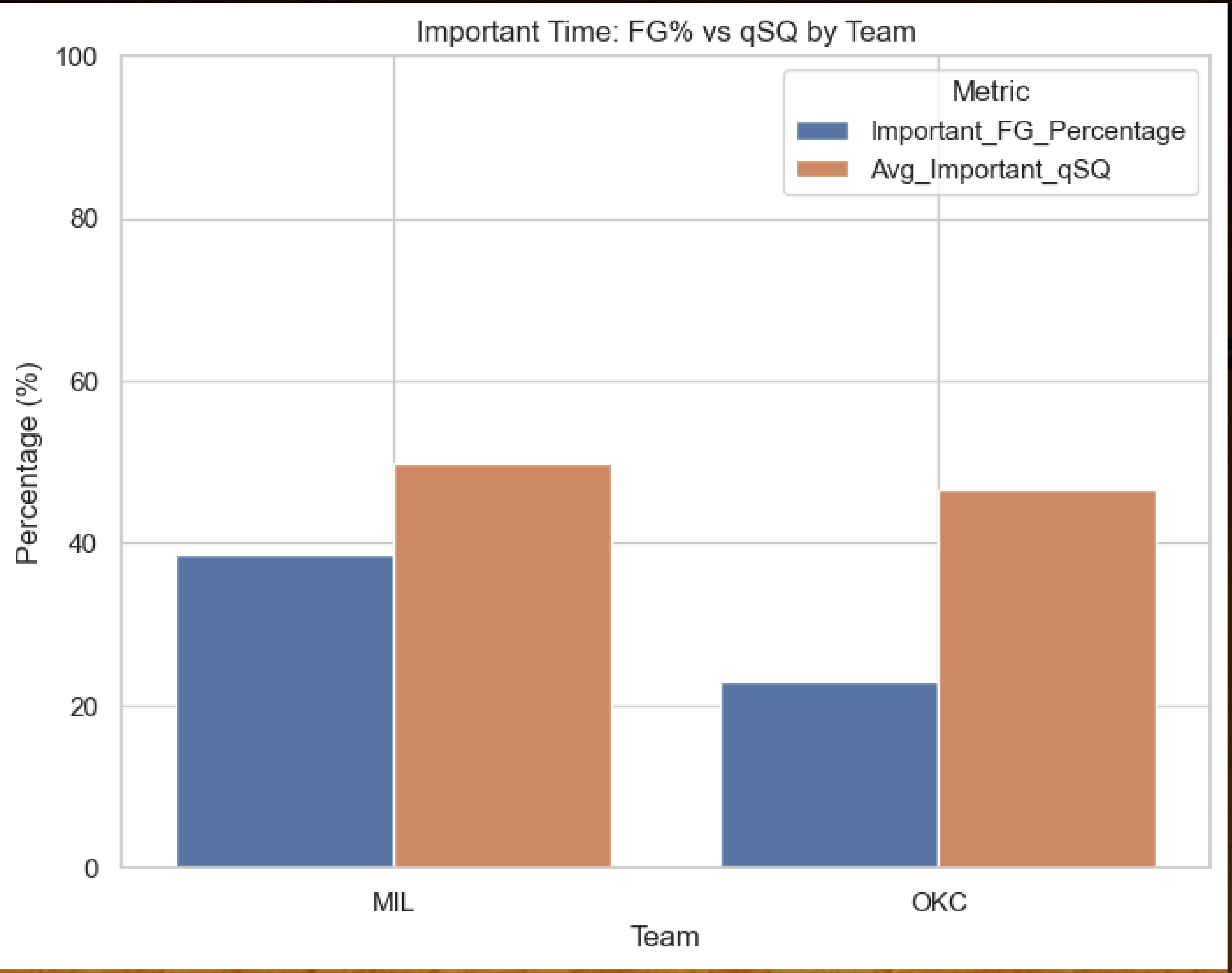


A5:Individual Shot Quality & Field Goal Percentage



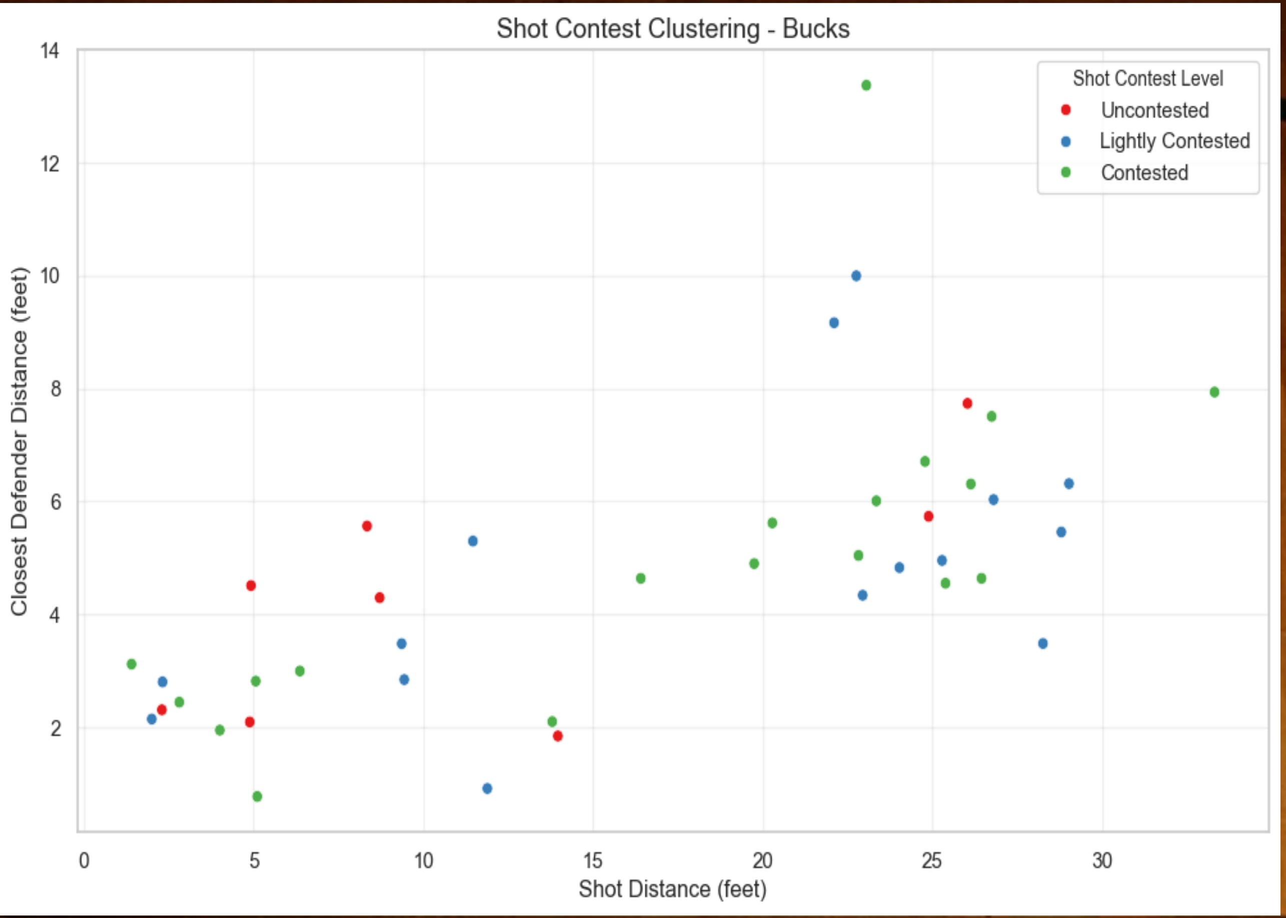
A6: Individual Shot Quality & Field Goal Percentage (Important Time)

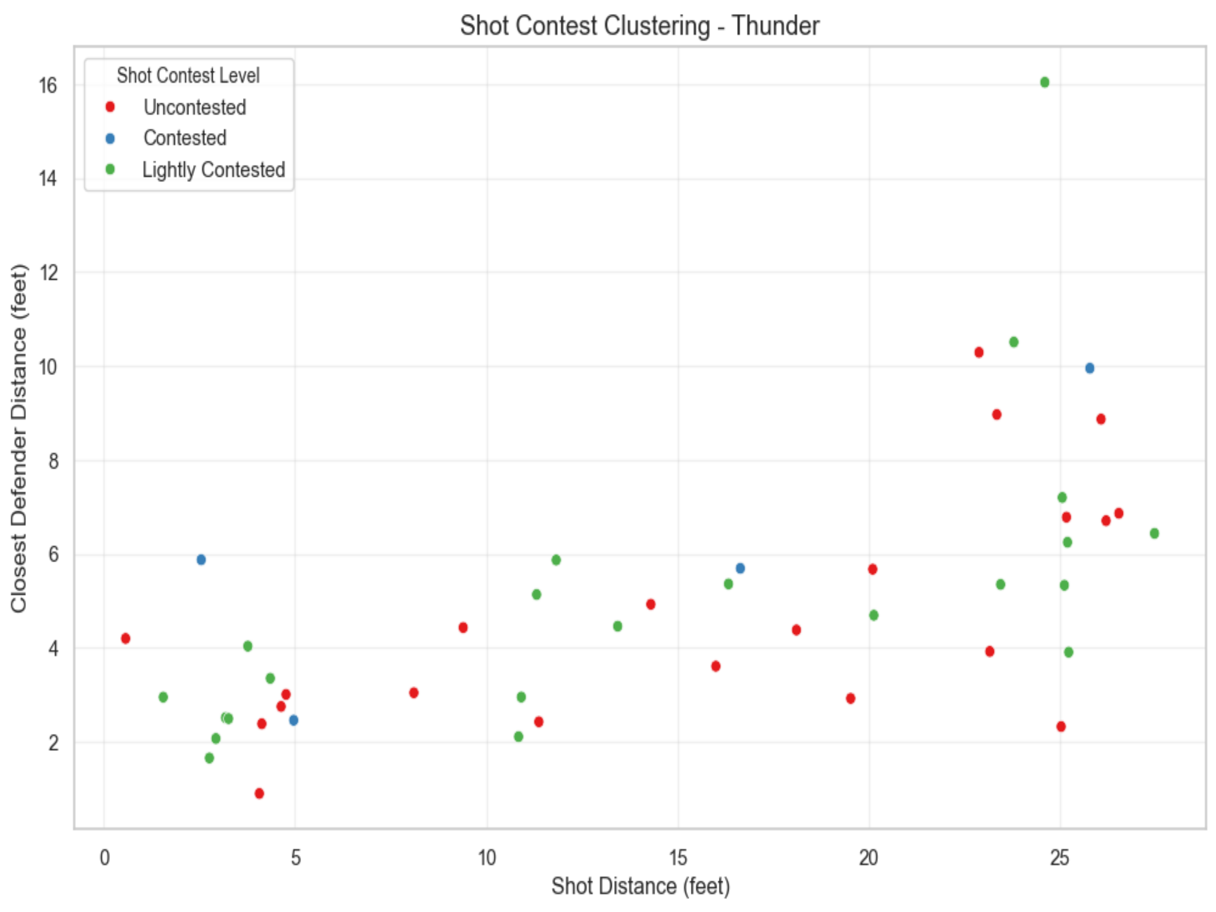




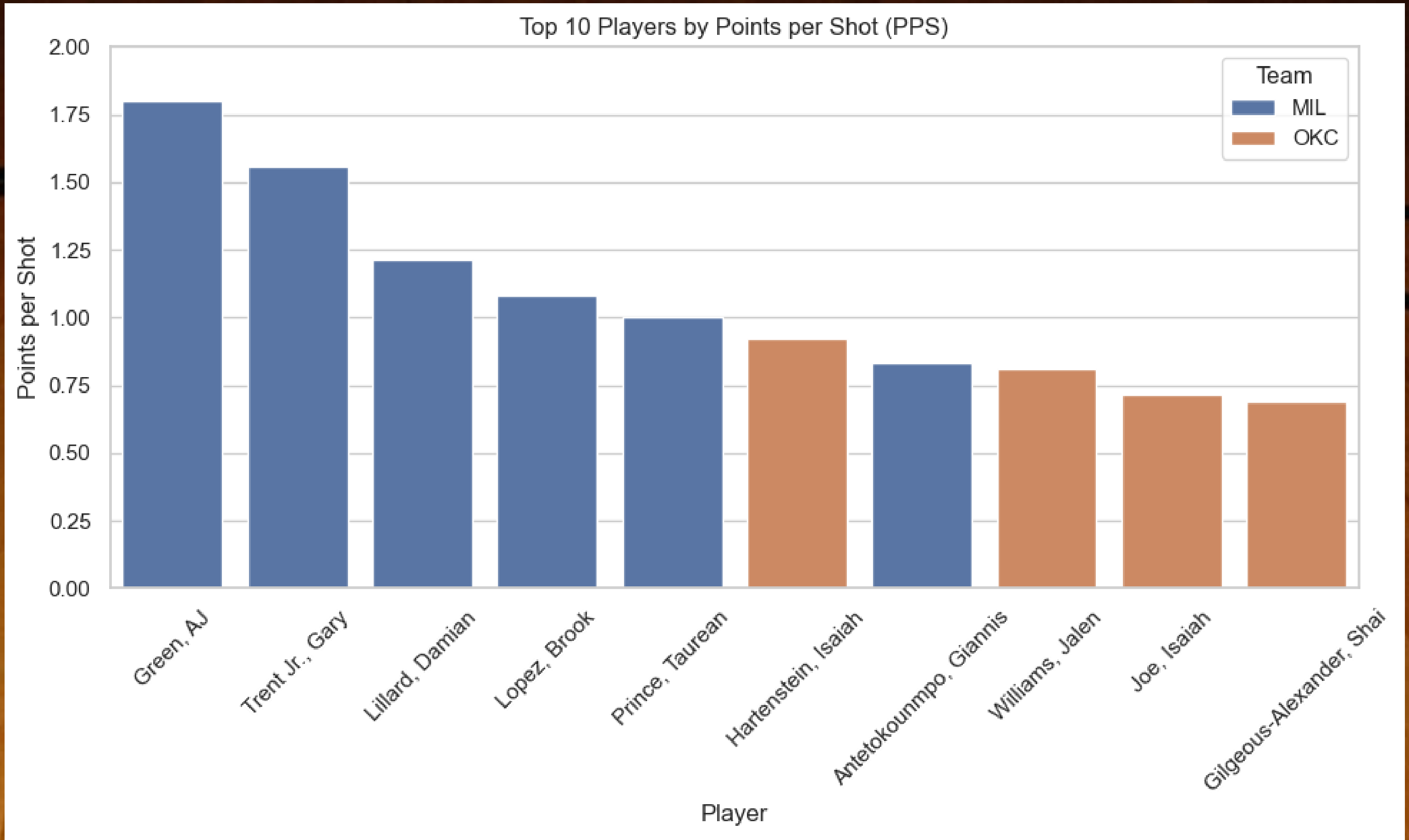
A7: Important Time: Last 4 Minutes of 1st and 2nd Quarters, Full 3rd Quarter (OKC vs MIL)

A8: Shot Contest Model

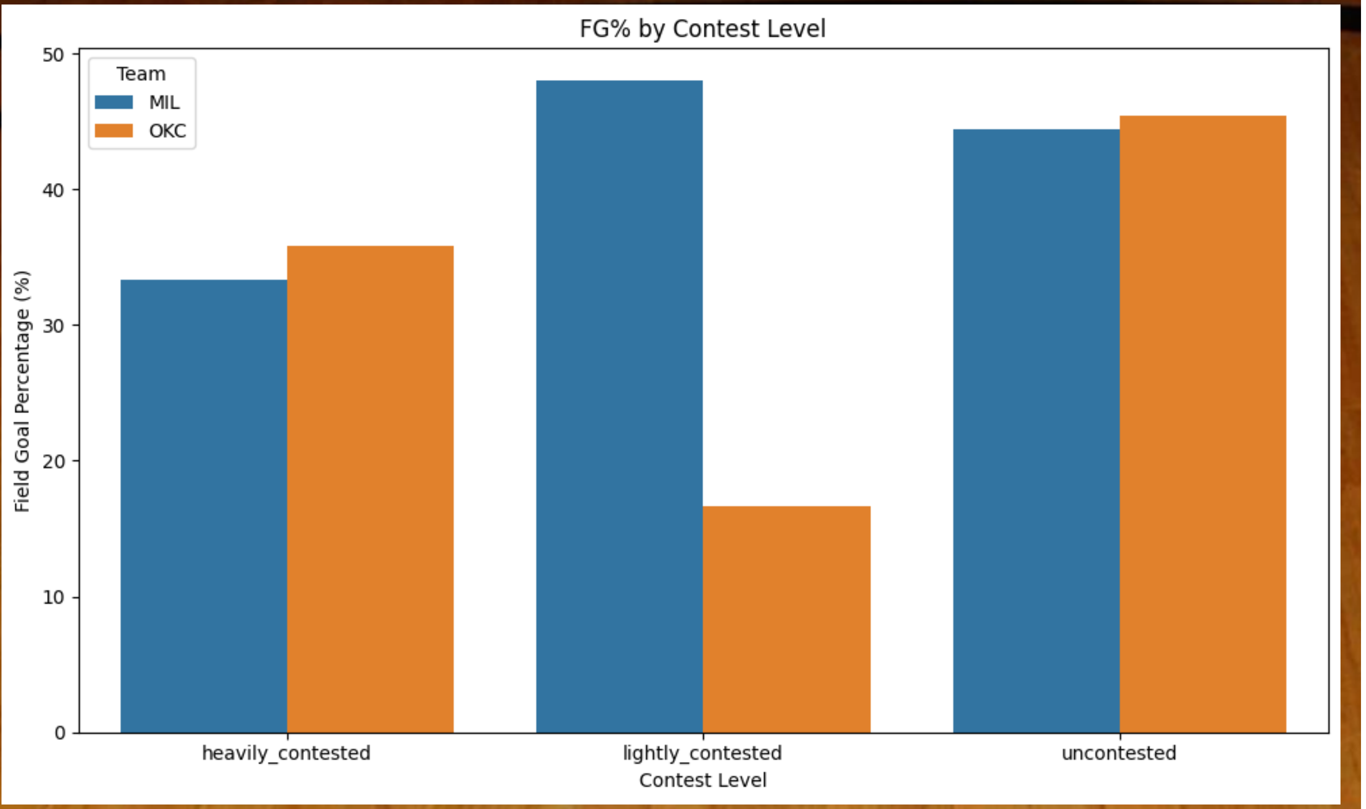


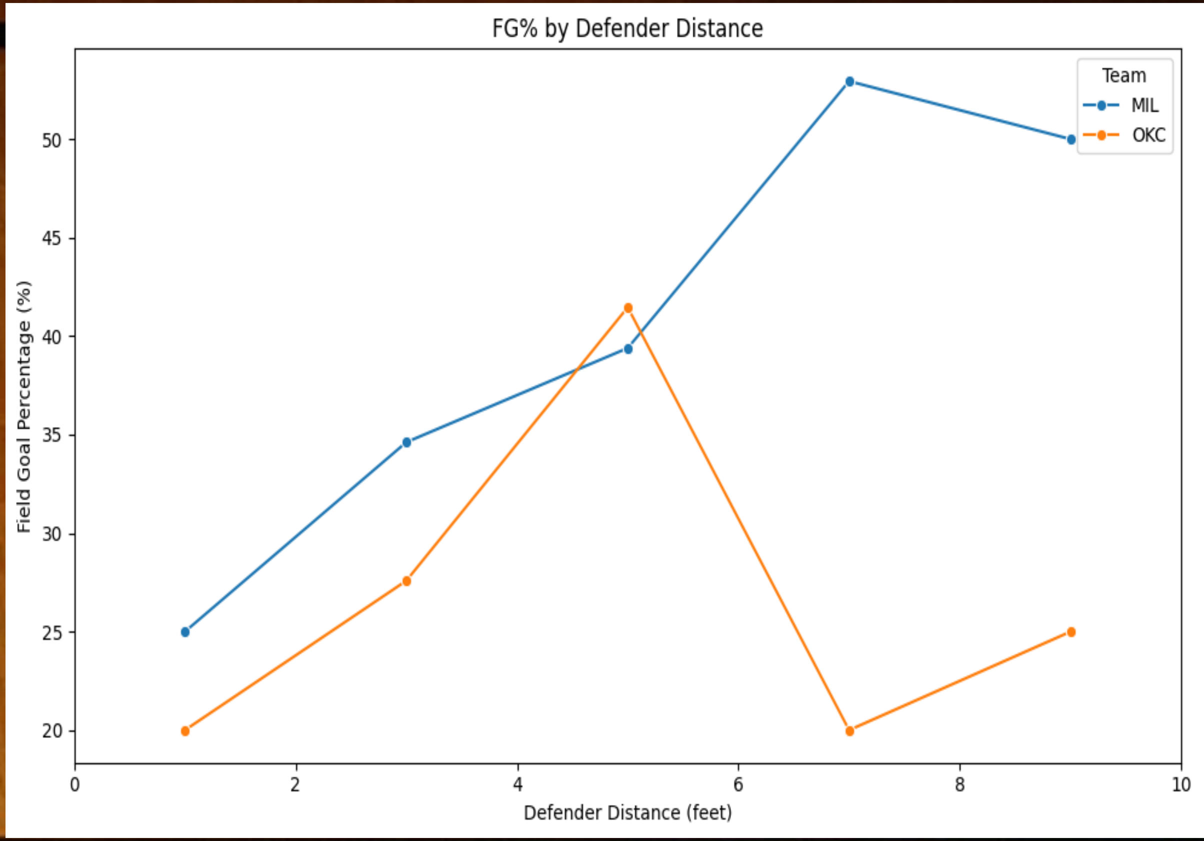


A9: Points Per Shot Top 10

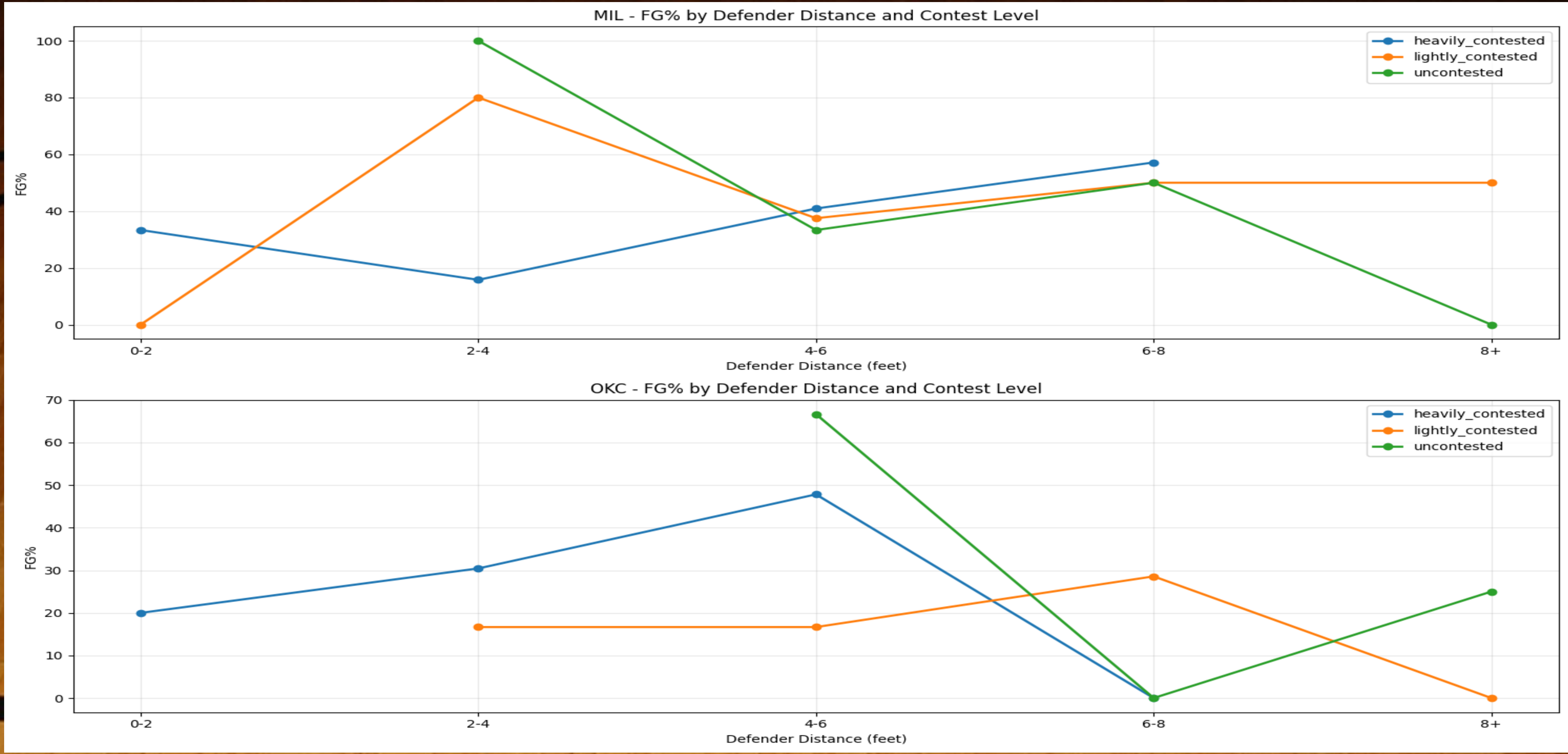


A10: Contest Level Graph Results & Defender Distance FG%

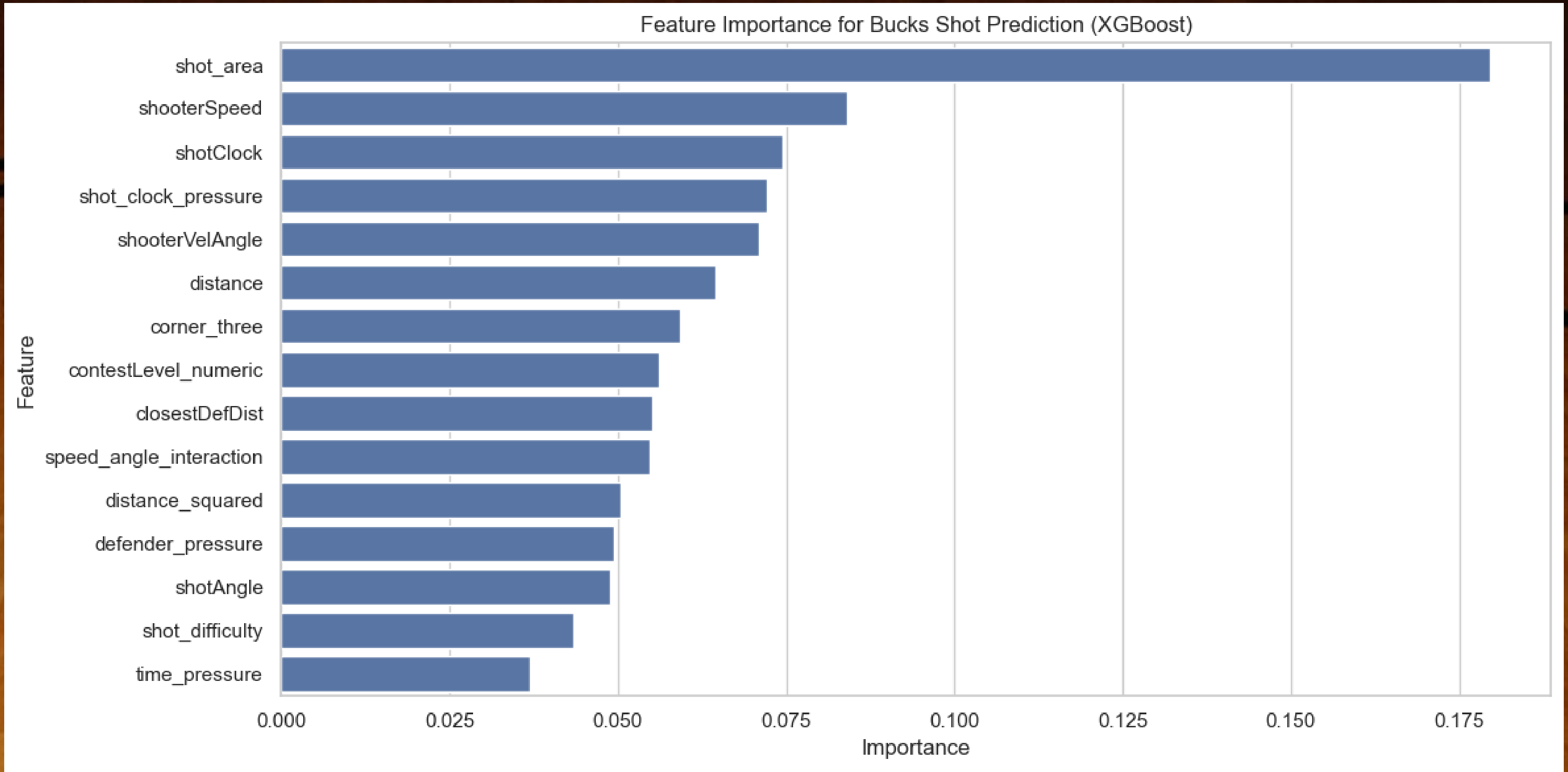




A11: Distance of Defender and Contest level



A12: Shot Prediction For the Milwaukee Bucks



Field Goal Percent (Angle & Shot Distance)